

Gideon Bullock

London, UK | gideonb@me.com | 07515 337955 | linkedin.com/in/gideonbullock

Design Leadership: VP Design, Head of Design, Design Director, Director of Product Design

PROFILE

Design leader who builds AI-native products and the organisations that ship them. Twenty-five years across consumer platforms, regulated enterprise and early-stage ventures, taking design from a service function to a commercially accountable part of the business.

Seven years at Toyota Connected Europe building an internal design consultancy from zero to 40+ designers, contributing over £10m in annual internal revenue with full P&L accountability across Europe, Japan and North America. Before that, eight years at Songkick as employee number seven and VP of Design, from seed through Series C to acquisition by Warner Music Group.

Since early 2026, operating at the multimodal AI layer: founder of a live AI voice product built on Hume and Anthropic APIs, founder of an emotion intelligence middleware venture under NDA with a tier-one automotive supplier, and experience architect for an AI-native venture studio. I specify, prototype and ship with agentic tooling rather than briefing it out.

EXPERIENCE

Independent

Founder and Product Advisor, AI Ventures | London | Feb 2026 to Present

Building and advising at the multimodal AI layer, hands-on. I specify, prototype and ship with agentic tooling rather than briefing it out.

- **PrepCall (founder)**. Designed, built and shipped a live AI voice coaching product end to end, on Next.js, Supabase, Stripe, Hume Empathic Voice Interface and the Anthropic API. Owned the compliance layer personally: EU AI Act classification, DPIA and privacy notice. Live ahead of marketing launch.
- **Emotrix (founder)**. Defined the architecture for engine-agnostic emotion intelligence middleware, the interpretation layer that turns facial and vocal signal into contextual meaning. Presented to FORVIA's XLab research organisation, signed a mutual NDA and agreed a pilot data arrangement. Originated from a proposal I authored inside Toyota's Global AI Initiative. Early stage, no product in market.
- **HUBIQ (experience architect)**. Authored the operating model for a solution foundry building AI-native ventures: a three-layer architecture and four-phase governance cycle, built on the premise that agentic coding makes building cheap and therefore makes building the wrong thing the dominant risk. Built and deployed the health venture's voice demonstrator.

Toyota Connected Europe

Head of UX and Product Design (Design Director level) | London | Dec 2018 to Feb 2026

Executive owner of design for Toyota Connected Europe. Founded and led TXD, an internal design consultancy of 40+ people supporting global programmes across Europe, Japan and North America, with full P&L accountability.

- Built a multi-disciplinary design organisation from zero to 40+ across product design, UX research, service design and design systems, embedded within product and engineering teams on three continents
- Held full commercial accountability for a function contributing over £10m in annual internal revenue, owning budget, utilisation, resourcing strategy and margin
- Replaced external agency dependency with an internal consultancy operating model, running land-and-expand engagement across multiple client teams
- Defined the operating model for design in a regulated global enterprise, moving product development from waterfall and output-focused delivery to outcome-driven development and continuous discovery
- Established career frameworks, progression models and leadership expectations across senior managers, leads and principals, delivering the highest permanent staff retention rate of any department in Toyota Connected
- Introduced service design as a core capability, connecting vehicle interfaces, mobile applications and physical service touchpoints through shared principles and structured governance
- Led design systems governance across app, web and in-vehicle multimedia, working with engineering on tokens, pipelines and cross-platform alignment
- Made accessibility non-negotiable across all digital and physical experiences, and led the establishment of European Accessibility Act governance and guidelines
- Authored the proposal to Toyota's Global AI Initiative for an AI-powered facial action coding system for in-cabin monitoring, including the internal accuracy testing that became the Emotrix thesis
- Design became one of the three core competencies of Toyota Connected Europe

Songkick (acquired by Warner Music Group)

VP of Design | London | Jun 2008 to Oct 2016

Employee number seven at the concert discovery platform. Executive team from seed through Series C (\$16.6m) to acquisition. Grew with the company to 130+ people and 15 million users.

- Led product design across web and mobile as the platform scaled to 10 million monthly active users and over \$100m in gross ticket revenue
- Drove the mobile-first product strategy that delivered a 43% increase in active users, with mobile passing 60% of platform traffic
- Built and led the design organisation, created the brand, and embedded design thinking and brand experience across the company
- Oversaw design for distribution partnerships with Spotify, YouTube, Facebook, SoundCloud and MTV
- Webby Award for Best Music Mobile Site/App. Fast Company 5th Most Innovative Company in Music. Music Week Consumer Digital Service of the Year

Dopay

Chief Design Officer | London and Cairo | Apr 2017 to Dec 2018

Executive design lead for a fintech delivering mobile payroll to unbanked workers in Egypt, where 67% of the population had no bank account. Concept to live commercial service.

- Directed design and launch of the Dopay for Business platform and the iOS and Android employee apps, reaching 85% user adoption within three weeks of launch
- Designed the physical Mastercard prepaid card that gave thousands of unbanked workers a first banking identity
- Built design practice and research operations from scratch, using research-led decisions to drive rapid iteration
- The product built in this period underpinned a subsequent €1m investment and \$18m Series A, with enterprise clients including McDonald's Egypt and SWVL

Lantum

Director of Product Design | London | Sep 2016 to Feb 2017

Joined during the pivot from labour marketplace to enterprise SaaS workforce management for the NHS, and the rebrand from Network Locum.

- Shaped the design function and product approach through the transition, defining how product, design and research would operate as the company scaled
- Led rebrand strategy, sourcing and directing an external branding agency on positioning and identity

Skype

Senior UX Designer | London | Oct 2004 to Sep 2007

Part of a small design team building the product through hyper-growth from 11 million to over 200 million registered users, and the \$2.6bn acquisition by eBay.

- Designed the onboarding and install flow, and the viral referral loop connecting sign-up directly to friend invitation, the mechanism behind growth at near-zero marketing spend
- Designed Skype for the Nokia N800 and N810, the first mobile Skype experiences, before the App Store existed
- Worked on Skypecasts, live voice conversations for up to 100 participants, fifteen years before Clubhouse

BBC New Media

Lead UX Designer | London | Nov 1998 to Nov 2004

Six years at the BBC through the formative era of digital product design, when user-centred design and usability testing were genuinely new disciplines.

- Led UX for the project that became BBC iPlayer, through genesis and early development
- Designed the global navigation and homepage for bbc.co.uk, then one of the most visited websites in the world
- Pioneered accessibility in partnership with the RNIB, working directly with developers on front-end architecture to support screen readers
- Led design teams across Radio 1, Doctor Who, BBC Science and BBC News. Collaborated with Neville Brody and Lambie-Nairn on BBC digital brand

Earlier

Rightster (t5m), Consultant, Oct 2007 to Feb 2008. Oyster Partners, UX Designer, Jan 1997 to Nov 1998. Webmedia, Web Designer, Oct 1994 to Jan 1997.

SKILLS

Design leadership and organisation: Design organisation leadership, operating model design, design operations, P&L and commercial accountability, career frameworks and progression, hiring and team building, executive stakeholder leadership, multi-geography team leadership, change leadership

AI and product: Multimodal AI, voice interfaces, agentic development workflows, AI product strategy, LLM application architecture, AI governance and EU AI Act compliance, prompt architecture, rapid prototyping with agentic tooling

Design practice: Product design strategy, service design, design systems governance, UX research and continuous discovery, accessibility and inclusive design (WCAG, European Accessibility Act), brand and experience strategy, cross-platform and multi-surface design

Technical: Next.js, React, TypeScript, Tailwind, Supabase, Vercel, Claude Code and agentic pipelines, Hume AI, Anthropic API, Figma, Playwright

ADDITIONAL

D&AD New Blood Awards, Judge, 2024 to 2025

General Assembly, Design Standards Board Member, 2019 to 2020

EDUCATION

Solent University, BA (Hons) Graphic Design, specialising in Interaction Design, 1992 to 1995

University for the Creative Arts, Foundation in Art and Design, 1991 to 1992